

Session 4 Worksheet: Understanding the Meaning I Give My Thoughts

CBT for OCD | Name: _____ Date: _____ Clinician: _____

In CBT for OCD, the problem is not the intrusive thought itself - almost everyone gets unwanted, odd, or disturbing thoughts. The problem is the MEANING (appraisal) we attach to the thought, and what we do in response. This session identifies the appraisals that keep the OCD going, so we can work on them.

Key idea: Intrusive thought (normal) -> Appraisal / meaning ("this is dangerous / my fault / says something about me") -> Distress -> Compulsion or avoidance -> Short-term relief -> the thought returns. We are looking at the middle step: the meaning.

A. The intrusive thought

The intrusive thought / image / urge: _____

Situation it happened in: _____

Distress (0-100): _____ Belief in the meaning (0-100%): _____

B. What does the thought make me think it MEANS? (the appraisal)

Common OCD appraisals - tick the ones that fit, and write your own version in your words.

Appraisal domain	What it sounds like in my head	Fits? (Y/N)
Inflated responsibility	"If I don't act, I'll be to blame if something bad happens."	
Thought-action fusion (likelihood)	"Thinking it makes it more likely to happen."	
Thought-action fusion (moral)	"Thinking it is as bad as doing it / means I'm bad."	
Over-importance of thoughts	"If I think it, it must be significant / true."	
Need to control thoughts	"I must get rid of / block this thought."	
Intolerance of uncertainty	"I have to be 100% sure nothing bad will happen."	
Overestimating threat	"The danger is huge and likely."	
Perfectionism	"I must do this exactly right / feel exactly right."	

C. Downward arrow - finding the core fear

Ask of each answer: "If that were true, what would it mean / what's so bad about that?"

The thought: _____

If that were true, it would mean... _____

...and if THAT were true, it would mean... _____

...the worst part / core fear is: _____

D. OCD thought record

Use this to catch appraisals during the week between sessions.

Trigger / situation	Intrusive thought	Meaning I gave it (appraisal)	Distress 0-100	What I did

E. Reflection

What did I notice about the meaning I attach to my thoughts?

Homework: complete the thought record when an intrusion occurs, without trying to fix the thought - just record it.